

EMILIE BURNHAM

PhD Student in Astronomy and Astrophysics
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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Galaxy formation and evolution; large-scale surveys; scientific software development; machine-learning; stellar population synthesis; SED fitting; cosmological simulations.

EDUCATION

The Pennsylvania State University

2023–2029

PhD, MS in Astronomy & Astrophysics

State College, PA, US

- Thesis Advisor: Dr. Joel Leja.

- Expected graduation date: May 2029.

Texas Christian University

2019–2022

BSc in Physics & Astronomy

Fort Worth, TX, US

- Thesis Advisor: Dr. Mia Bovill.

- Graduated summa cum laude.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Penn State University

2023–

Graduate Research Assistant

State College, PA, US

Developed tools (ESPS, PIGLET) to enable fast modeling of galaxy spectra in large surveys. Applied these tools to infer the recent star formation histories of galaxy populations across cosmic time, with a particular emphasis on burstiness. Presented results at conferences and seminars, and published research in peer-reviewed journals.

Cosmic Dawn Center (DAWN), Neils Bohr Institute, University of Copenhagen

2026

Copenhagen, Denmark

NSF DAWN IRES Senior Scholar

Mentored undergraduate students participating in the program and led workshops on research skills used in the field of galaxy formation and evolution. Continued thesis research while in residence at DAWN.

University of Colorado at Boulder

2021

NSF REU Research Assistant

Remote

Conducted research on how well modern radiative transfer codes can recover the absorption features in different spatial features (e.g., plage, faculae) of the solar disk. Presented results at the 2021 Winter American Geophysical Union meeting.

Texas Christian University

2020–2023

Undergraduate Research Assistant

Fort Worth, TX, US

Conducted research on modeling the observable effects of a warm dark matter cosmology in the JWST era. Reduced spectra of nearby open clusters to calculate alpha element abundances. Presented results at the 2023 Winter American Astronomical Society meeting.

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

Front Line Mobile Health, PLLC

2023–2024

Clinical Data Analyst

Georgetown, TX, US

Conducted research on the health of first responders. Developed a data pipeline to analyze and visualize health data to employers of first responders.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Penn State University	2026
<i>Undergraduate Research Mentor, Students Together for Astronomical Research (STAR) State College, PA Program</i>	
Penn State University	2025
<i>Guest Lecturer, ASTRO 291: Astronomical Methods and the Solar System State College, PA</i>	
Texas Christian University	2023
<i>Teaching Assistant, PHYS 10293: Archeoastronomy Fort Worth, TX</i>	
Texas Christian University	2022
<i>Teaching Assistant, PHYS 20475: Physics I for Majors Fort Worth, TX</i>	

FIRST-AUTHOR PUBLICATIONS

- [1] Emilie Burnham, Bingjie Wang, Joel Leja, Owen Gonzales, Jenny E Greene, Kartheik G Iyer, Abby Mintz, David J Setton, Sarah Wellons, Rachel Bezanson, and others. *It's More Complicated Than You Think: A Forward Model to Infer the Recent Star Formation History, Bursty or Not, of Galaxy Populations* The Astrophysical Journal (2026).

HONORS AND AWARDS

Harold and Nancy O'Connor Graduate Excellence Fund Scholarship	2025
<i>Penn State Eberly College of Science</i>	
Frymoyer Award	2025
<i>Institute of Gravitation and the Cosmos</i>	
Zaccheus Daniel Foundation for Astronomical Science Scholarship	2025
<i>Penn State Department of Astronomy and Astrophysics</i>	
University Graduate Fellowship	2024
<i>Penn State University</i>	
Stephen B. Brumbach Distinguished Graduate Fellowship in Science	2023
<i>Penn State University</i>	
Verne M. Willaman Distinguished Graduate Fellowship in Science	2023
<i>Penn State University</i>	
Homer F. Braddock Scholarship in Biology, Chemistry, and Physics	2023
<i>Penn State University</i>	
Dr. C.A. Quarles Physics and Astronomy Scholarship	2021
<i>Texas Christian University Department of Physics and Astronomy</i>	
Joseph Morgan Physics Scholarship	2021
<i>Texas Christian University Department of Physics and Astronomy</i>	
Bob Bolen Leadership Scholarship	2021
<i>The Sarah & Ross Perot Jr. Foundation, Texas Christian University</i>	

TCU Scholar **2021**
Texas Christian University

College of Science and Engineering Dean's List **2019**
Texas Christian University College of Science and Engineering. Six-time awardee.

LEADERSHIP AND SERVICE

Astronomy on Tap State College Organizer **2024–**
Astronomy on Tap State College State College, PA
Organized monthly public talks on astronomy topics, coordinated with speakers, and promoted events to engage the local community in astronomy outreach.

Society of Physics Students (SPS) President and Treasurer **2021–2022**
Texas Christian University Chapter of the Society of Physics Students Fort Worth, TX
Led the student chapter of the Society of Physics Students, organized events and meetings, managed finances, and coordinated events to grow participation across departments.

OUTREACH

Public Lecture on "Why is Astronomy a Big Data Field?" **2025**
Astronomy on Tap State College State College, PA

Public Lecture on "The Milky Way Through the Rainbow" **2024**
Astro Night at Penn State State College, PA

Public Lecture on "Surprises at the Edge of the Universe Found with JWST" **2024**
Central Pennsylvania Observer's Society State College, PA

PROFESSIONAL PRESENTATIONS

Invited Talks

- *"It's More Complicated Than You Think: Inferring the Recent Star Formation History, Bursty or Not, in Galaxy Populations"*
 - Penn State University Center for Astrostatistics and Astroinformatics Lunch Seminar | State College, PA | 2026
 - University of Copenhagen Cosmic Dawn Center (DAWN) Cake Talk Seminar | Copenhagen, Denmark | 2026
 - University of Pittsburgh Joint Extragalactic Group Meeting | Pittsburgh, PA | 2025
 - Penn State University Institute for Gravitation and the Cosmos Primordial Universe and Gravitation Seminar | State College, PA | 2025
 - Princeton University Galactic/Extragalactic Reading Group | Princeton, NJ | 2025

Contributed Talks

- *"It's More Complicated Than You Think: Inferring the Recent Star Formation History, Bursty or Not, in Galaxy Populations"*
 - Eberly Research Showcase | State College, PA | 2025 | (First-place prize)
 - Penn State University Department of Astronomy and Astrophysics Lunch Talk Seminar | State College, PA | 2025
 - 7th Neighborhood Workshop on Astrophysics and Cosmology | State College, PA | 2025 | (First-place prize)
- *"The Need for Speed in Galaxy Evolution Surveys"*
 - Penn State Astronomy and Astrophysics Lunch Talk Seminar | State College, PA | 2025
- *"Measuring the Family Histories of Bursty Star Formation within Galaxy Populations"*
 - Penn State Astronomy and Astrophysics Lunch Talk Seminar | State College, PA | 2024
- *"Forensic Astronomy"*
 - Texas Christian University Annual Student Research Symposium | Fort Worth, TX | 2021

Contributed Posters

- *“It’s More Complicated Than You Think: Inferring the Recent Star Formation History, Bursty or Not, in Galaxy Populations”*
 - Carnegie Mellon University Statistical Methods for the Physical Sciences Research Center Workshop | Pittsburgh, PA | 2025 | (simulation-based inference)
 - Penn State University Institute for Computational Data Sciences Symposium | State College, PA | 2025 | (computational methods)
- *“Warm or Cold Dark Matter? A Love-Heat Relationship”*
 - Texas Christian University Annual Student Research Symposium | Fort Worth, TX | 2022
 - American Astronomical Society Winter Meeting | Seattle, WA | 2023
- *“Spectral Runway: An Analysis of Solar Balmer Lines through Observations and Models”*
 - American Geophysical Union Winter Meeting | New Orleans, LA | 2021

SKILLS

Computing: Python, JAX, Machine Learning, Data Analysis, Data Visualization, Software Development, High-Performance Computing, Git, Cloud Computing, GPUs